

« BEFORE

In the early years of the conflict, the majority of Americans backed US participation in the war.

AMERICAN OPINION

The **Tonkin Gulf Incident** in 1964 led to a massive escalation of the US military presence in Indochina. Yet most Americans had been too preoccupied with the Civil Rights Movement and the 1960s' counterculture to question America's role in Vietnam. More than **half of all Americans** approved of the war effort in polls conducted by Gallup in 1965 and 1966.



BADGE OF PRIDE

By 1967, the Vietnam War had ground to a bloody stalemate, with neither side capable of achieving a final or even partial victory. The American military and its allies had proved adept at winning conventional battles, while the NVA and the Viet Cong excelled at gaining the upper hand in smaller skirmishes and at controlling large parts of the South Vietnamese countryside through guerrilla warfare.

Constant pounding

The number of American troops stationed in South Vietnam had grown by more than 100,000 by the end of 1966, reaching an all-time high of nearly half a million GIs spread between the Mekong Delta and the DMZ. Viet Cong positions in South Vietnam were pounded with B-52 Arc Light raids on a daily basis, as well as by naval guns and ground artillery.

Some 20,000 US troops had already been killed in action, yet Lyndon B. Johnson was pouring ever more men and machines into the anticommunist cause and there was no reason to believe the escalation would abate.

The communist leadership determined that the only way to break the stalemate—and snatch victory—was to undertake a massive military offensive against multiple targets in South Vietnam. At best, the assault might topple the South Vietnamese regime outright and drive the Americans into the South China Sea. At worst, it would demonstrate the